

RC32 NEWSLETTER

Summer/ Fall 2021

Volume #12

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PRESIDENT'S MESSAGE

Welcome to New and Continuing RC32 members,



Figure 1. Dr. Melanie Heath, RC 32
President

I hope that you and your family are safe as we continue to deal with soaring COVID rates due to the Delta variant in many parts of the world, and with the catastrophic effects of climate change. Worldwide cases of COVID now surpass 209,000,000, and there have been more than 4,390,000 deaths. We are seeing global climate disasters across the world, fueling weather extremes, record drought, disastrous fires, and massive floods, and fueling massive shortages of water and food in many parts of the world. Every day grim news arrives for women, girls, non-binary, and LGBTQ+ people across the globe. In the last few weeks, it has been especially disheartening to witness the fall of Afghanistan to the Taliban and the brutal impact that this will have on the lives of women and minorities across the country.

I begin this message on a grim note as a reminder to us, as a feminist community, for the need to come together to support each other in our fight for social justice. In that vein, beginning in mid-October, I will be hosting a monthly (or bi-monthly) one-hour Zoom meeting for RC32 members to facilitate feminist networks and offer encouragement during these difficult times. We will focus on topics of importance to members, and when possible, I will invite speakers to provide a focus for our discussion. Please email our secretary Alicia Palermo (aliciaipalermo@gmail.com) with suggestions for topics and keep your eyes out for an email with more information.

Another way that RC32 members have participated in community-building during COVID-19 has been to submit chapters for the forthcoming book to be published with Routledge titled, *Global Feminist Autoethnographies During COVID-19: Displacements and Disruptions*. It is co-edited by RC32 members Akosua K. Darkwah, Josephine Beoku-Betts, Bandana Purkayastha, and me, and uses feminist methods to reflect on our experiences of precarities as tenured faculty, faculty on temporary contracts, and graduate students during COVID-19. Many RC32 members contributed to bear witness to the displacements, disruptions, and distress experienced by women in different locations in academia. I want to thank RC32 member Jeff Hearn, who is an editor for the book series, *Routledge Advances in Feminist Studies and Intersectionality*, in which the book will appear. Please watch out for it in early 2022.

On February 23-27, 2021, RC32 participated in the virtual IV Forum of the International Sociological Association. RC32's sub-theme was "Global Inequalities in the 21st Century: Gender,

Sexualities, Intimacies, and Intersectionality,” and it hosted 26 regular and joint sessions. In this newsletter, I provide a summary and photos of some of the highlights of the Forum. We also have a feature article by Manashi Ray, and the minutes from our business meeting.

Our new RC32 website is now live at <https://www.isa-rc32.org>. There you can find our newsletters, including the feature article from each edition, information about past and upcoming ISA Forums and Congresses, and membership information. We will be updating it periodically.

Regarding the XX ISA World Congress of Sociology that was scheduled to take place in Melbourne, Australia in July 2022, after much consultation and discussion in the ISA Executive Committee and in the ISA Research Council that I participated in on several occasions as RC32 President, as well as a survey of ISA members, a decision was reached to postpone the conference until June 2023. The decision was made based on the importance of prioritizing equity due to uneven COVID outbreaks, differential vaccine access, and Australia’s strict admission policies. The hope is that postponing the Congress will enable more people to participate in person, a priority that RC members from the global North and South expressed in the survey.

With the postponement of the World Congress, I will work with the Board and Regional Representatives to plan a virtual three-day conference in summer 2022 that will focus on research on the global South—highlighting challenges faced due to COVID-19 and global climate change. If you have ideas for this conference, please email me at rc32president2018@gmail.com.

I hope to meet you at one of our upcoming RC32 Zoom meetings. Please take care and stay safe!



Melanie Heath

FORUM HIGHLIGHTS

RC32 President's Report of the IV ISA Virtual Forum of Sociology *Challenges of the 21st Century: Democracy, Environment, Inequalities, Intersectionality* February 23-28, 2021

Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the IV ISA Forum of Sociology—planned to take place in Porto Alegre, Brazil in 2020—was postponed and moved online to become the first virtual Forum in February 2021. RC32: Women, Gender, and Society had a very successful meeting, hosting 26 regular sessions, including eight joint sessions. Its sub-theme was “Global Inequalities in the 21st Century: Gender, Sexualities, Intimacies, and Intersectionality,” and RC32’s sessions brought together scholars from around the world and had a strong presence of members from the global South. To support global South scholars and students, RC32 was able to cover the registration costs for members from Category C countries who participated in the meetings. Below are a few highlights.

The Board wants to thank all RC32 organizers, chairs, presenters, and participants for making the Forum so successful! Recordings of RC32 sessions are available on the ISA website for the Forum under RC32 Women, Gender, and Society (<https://isaconf.confex.com/isaconf/forum2020/meetingapp.cgi/Symposium/598>).



RC32 President Melanie Heath organized a Past-President's Special Joint Session with RC05: Racism, Nationalism, Indigeneity, and Ethnicity in honor of the memory of Ann Denis (1945-2019), who was an active member and served as Vice-President of RC32 from 1998 to 2006 and as

President of RC05 from 2010-2014. Her research and publications focused on power relations within and between societies, particularly on the intersections of gender, ethnicity/race, and class with work, and on intersectionality within feminisms. In line with the RC32 sub-theme: “Global Inequalities in the 21st Century: Gender, Sexualities, Intimacies, and Intersectionality,” the session considered how global challenges that societies face today are fundamentally tied to inequalities of gender, race, class, intimate citizenship, and disability. Presenters included Margaret Abraham, Hofstra University, USA; Nira Yuval-Davis, University of East London, United Kingdom; Evangelia Tastsoglou, Saint Mary's University, Canada; and Rhoda Reddock, The University of the West Indies, Trinidad and Tobago.

While we were not able to gather in person in Brazil, RC32 offered sessions with a strong Latin-American thematic and included important scholars from Latin countries. RC32 Secretary Alicia Itati Palermo organized a Commons Session with RC10: Participation, Organizational Democracy and Self-Management, GT CLASCO: Critical thinking and emancipatory practices, and GT Argentinian Sociological Association: Gender and Society titled, "Gender, Democracy and Inequality in Latin America" (co-chaired with past ISA President Margaret Abraham). This session examined how current setback in rights has increased inequality in one of the most unequal regions of the world—Latin America, and how nationalist politics weaken democracies through authoritarian methods of control. In many countries in Latin America, social protest is criminalized, social expenditures are being cut, and precarious employment grows. The panelists discussed how gender inequalities and their intersections with race, class, sexuality, among others, can be analyzed considering right-wing setbacks, as well as movements for social justice. Presenters included Bula Bhadra of Sister Nivedita University, New Town, Kolkata, India; Martha Nélida Ruiz Uribe of Rector of the University of Tijuana, Mexico; and Ana Cárdenas Tomazic of the Institut für Sozialwissenschaftliche Forschung ISF München.

A RC32 session that complemented the Commons Session was organized by Co-Presidents Elect Solange Simoes and Marlise Matos Almeida titled, "The 'New Right' War on Gender and Intersectional Responses across the World." It featured papers that first discussed the Brazilian experience given this year's ISA Forum location in Brazil, and the radical change in gender policies (including policies for women and LGBTQI + segments) that have taken place in Brazil and Latin America in the last decades—from the Pink Tide, in which the states in the region actively engaged in policy initiatives to address gender inequalities (new legislation, program creation, and varying public policy actions) to the arrivals of self-proclaimed New Right governments that have been leading to serious conservative setbacks and threats on the agenda to promote gender equality. It then turned to papers that considered the convergences and distinctions in both the "New Right" as well as in the feminist responses in various global locations, and the resulting possibilities of renewed forms of transnational feminist solidarities and alliances. Presenters included Marlise Matos Almeida, Universidade Federal de Minas Gerais, Brazil; Sonia Correa, ABIA/Sexuality Policy Watch – SPW, Brazil; Manisha Desai, University of Connecticut, USA; Janet Conway, Brock University, Canada; and Analia Torres, CIEG/ISCSP University of Lisbon, Portugal.

RC32 hosted an Author Meets Critics session for books published in 2019. It offered a lively discussion of four books: *Women in Place: The Politics of Gender Segregation in Iran* by Nazanin Shahrokni (2019, University of California Press) with discussants Azam Khatam, The City Institute,



Canada, and Ayse Saktanber, Middle East Technical University, Turkey; *Gender and Migration: Transnational and Intersectional Prospects* by Anna Amelina and Helma Lutz (Routledge, 2019); and *Advances in Gender Research* (Volumes 27 and 28), by Vicky Demos, Marcia Segal, and Kristy Kelly.

Here are the names of other sessions you might want to listen to if you didn't get a chance to at the Forum in February:

- Decolonial and Intersectional Feminisms: Weaving Friendships, Alliances and Liberation Politics Gender Violence and Experiences of Discrimination
- Interrogating Sexualities and Intimacies: The Liberatory and Oppressive Politics of the 21st Century.
- Gender, Violence and Migration
- Gender, Language, and Politics
- Women and Leadership
- Intersectional Approaches to Gender, Diversities and Inequalities Regarding the MENA Region
- Cadences of Everyday Gendered Migrant Lives
- Decolonizing Gender: Gender Diversity from a Transnational Perspective
- Gender Equality in the Rural Sector: The Ever Persistent Challenge
- Women, Migration, and Work
- Gender and Professions
- Neoliberalism, Inequalities, and the Gendered Everyday
- The Intersectional Discrimination of Gender Violence Due to Gender and Race
- Gendered Resistances in Postcolonial and Transnational Context
- Global Gender Occupational Inequality
- Global Perspectives on Gender, Family, Labor, and Migration
- Youth, Gender and Place
- Culture, Religion, and Gender Inequality
- Women's Careers and the Process of Civilization
- Marginal, Informal, Precarious: Studying Work from an Intersectional
- Perspective in Different Societal and Spatial Contexts
- The Use of Language in Media, Disruptions in Hegemonic Meanings, and the Resistance to Gender Violence

MINUTES OF RC 32 BUSINESS MEETING

Feb 26, 2021

Submitted by: **Secretary Alicia Itati Palermo**
(with Treasurer Manashi Ray)

For the IV ISA Virtual Forum of Sociology, the RC32 Business Meeting was held on February 26, 2021, presided over by **Melanie Heath**, Chair of RC32, who welcomed participants and introduced the meeting agenda. She presented the main activities and initiatives carried out since 2018. These include the creation of a new RC32 website (<https://www.isa-rc32.org>). I find the design and the possibility of having this RC32 website excellent, which makes our RC highly visible.

Melanie detailed the RC32 program for the ISA forum, which hosted 26 sessions:

- RC32 was participating in 9 joint sessions and is hosting 5 of these, including JS-48 Past-President's Special Session: Global Inequalities of Gender, Race, Class, Intimate Citizenship, and Disability in honor of long-time RC32 member Ann Denis, Professor Emerita at the University of Ottawa, who passed away on February 5, 2019.
- Commons Session: Gender, Democracy, and Inequality in Latin America. Participating RCs and Latin American Societies: RC32, RC10, GT CLASCSO, and GT Argentinian Sociological Association: Gender and Society.

She reported on other initiatives, including with SWS and its Global Partners that sought submissions for a co-edited autoethnography publication examining global portrayals of our lives as academics and practitioners in our particular social contexts during this traumatic period of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The second presentation was in my charge, ie. **Alicia Itati Palermo**, RC32 secretary. In addition to the responsibilities assigned to the Secretariat by the Statute of RC32, the following activities were carried out with the purpose of further involving the members of RC 32:

- Exchange with membership in relation to specific topics and keeping an up-to-date membership list.
- Dissemination of activities (events, calls, publications, among other activities), of interest to the members.
- Organization of activities with other Research Committees and regional associations.
- Following the suggestion of the regional representative for Europe, Capitolina Díaz, we will seek to organize a space for reflection on the consequences of the COVID-19 crisis from a gender perspective. The idea is that the regional representatives of RC32 participate in this initiative.

Third, our treasurer, **Manashi Ray**, presented the financial status of the RC32:

- The RC32 has 340 members, and its income as of February 4, 2021, from affiliation fees is € 12,242.88 or US \$ 14.808.

She reported on the Activity Grant to support RC32 activities:

- 2019 – Grant from ISA to support RC32 activities for Brazil conference and pre-conference workshop = € 1,960 (cancelled due to pandemic)
- 2021 – Registration costs for RC32 presenters at the virtual conference at Brazil in February 2021 = € 265
- 2021 – Building of RC32 website and maintenance fees for 2 years = € 1,690

Finally, **newsletter editor, Shweta Majumdar Adur**, reported on the two newsletters that she edited in the past year. She also asked members to write to the newsletter editor or secretary if they had news to report.

After presentations by the Board, the regional representatives presented their initiatives:

Bula Bhadra from India

- In the last 3 years, India witnessed 3 movements –Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and National Register of Citizens (NRC) and the Farmers movement. Women played a huge role in these protests, particularly in and around New Delhi. The government tried to dismantle these movements, finally it was the spread of COVID that dispelled this protest.
- India declared a sudden lockdown on March 24th.
- The anti-farmers' movement arose, probably the biggest in the world. This struggle is still ongoing.
- During the lockdown imposed by the Indian government, there has been a rapid increase of domestic violence and unprecedented rates of rape. The National Commission of Women had to issue a WhatsApp #, for women to have easy access for help.
- It was a very turbulent year, but in these circumstances, women have shown resistance to conservative neoliberal positions. For example:
 - a) Love Jihad – where love between Muslim men and Hindu women is accused by Hindus as an instrument of forcible conversion. One of most populous states in India has passed a law to that effect.
- Bula is trying to co-ordinate an All India study on Domestic Violence with an intersectional focus to consider whether class and region have increased the rate of domestic violence.
- There is a rise of the women's movement and women's spirit in India, despite the gloomy scenario.

Rima Majed from Beirut

- The situation in Lebanon and the Middle East has not been very different. Scholars are bridging between their research agenda and feminist activism with movements.
- This is also the region with the highest rates of inequalities, unemployment, and war and violence. And this impacts women's lives negatively.

- We have come a very long way, especially when it comes to family status laws, family laws etc.
- There have been women's uprisings in the region, particularly on the issue of political motherhood—how the concept of motherhood is deployed in movement.
- It is also important and necessary to see these regions of global South are an area for production of theory and feminism from the vantage of point of Middle East.
- There have been many publications that bridge scholarly work with feminist activism.
- The pandemic has intensified the struggle that we were already facing.

Agatha Eguavoen from Nigeria

- There has been a significant increase of domestic violence and rape of girls and women within and outside the family circle during COVID.
- The increase has been 91% for female assault during COVID-19.
- Female children have been abused and molested. There were fathers, uncles and relatives who molested their children, because they were locked in. This has increased the abortion rates.
- There has been an increase in dropout rates of girls from schools, particularly in rural area.
- There is a high rate of women's unemployment during COVID.
- Women are unable to go to their farms because of harassment and rape by male headsman.
- Emergence of "baby factories," where young women are kidnapped and kept in isolation, then impregnated by the owner or the son of the owner. They are paid off once the child is born and the child is sold off.
- Initiatives include visiting schools to sensitize young adolescent women why they should speak out when they find themselves in such situations.
- "Speak out" is the watch word when they are faced with such situations.
- There continues to be a problem of Female Genital Mutilation, which is quite prevalent in rural areas despite the VAPP Act.
- 300 school children were kidnapped for a ransom, and they are still in custody, just like in Chibok in 2014.
- We need world support for addressing these issues.

Jan Marie Fritz and hara bastas from the United States

- The report from the United States included information on the Global Feminist Partnership Program (GFPP), which represents Sociologists for Women & Society's commitment to activism and advocacy for global gender justice. The goal is to strengthen the relationships between global feminist organizations while directly supporting the mission of SWS on "promoting social justice research within local, national, and international activist spaces." Global partners contribute to the development of sociological feminist theory and scholarship while centering collaborations with international feminist organizations.
- If RC32 members want to suggest new partners, please contact GFPP subcommittee chair, Rita Stephen (rita.stephan@gmail.com).

Capitolina Díaz from Europe

- She introduced the EU Recover Fund from COVID-19 as an opportunity for feminist academics and activists. It includes 1,8 million € to be used on:
 - research and innovation,
 - climate and digital transitions,
 - new health program
 - cohesion and the common agricultural policy,
 - fight against climate change,
 - biodiversity and **gender equality**
- She introduced a proposal for working on COVID-19 gender inequalities, suggesting the possibility of organizing (with the RC 32 Secretary Alicia Palermo) a space for reflection on the consequences of the crisis caused by COVID-19 from a gender perspective, which could be “workshops” in Spanish for Latin America and Spain. The idea is that the regional representatives of RC32 participate in this initiative. An example of this has been done by European Gender Sociology.
- Some aspects to consider are the differential effects on women and men of COVID-19, the demographic aspects, family relations, and education.
- She provided a report from other countries.

After the reports, Melanie Heath asked members whether they support RC32 writing a letter in support of nominating Raewyn Connell for the Gender Justice Award. There was agreement. Members made suggestions of items to include in the letter from their own experiences of working with Raewyn.

Melanie closed the meeting with information on the Congress in Melbourne on Resurgent Authoritarianism.

FEATURE ARTICLE

Kolkata Under Covid: Reflections on a Visit Home, Winter 2020-21

By Dr. Manashi Ray

Most days I get to speak with my mother, who is now 86 years old, twice a day. We talk briefly on the phone, me in my home in the US and she in Kolkata, India, where she lives with two caregivers. Normally, I go home twice a year to visit her. But since the beginning of 2020, every night I have gone to bed thinking of her and other loved ones in India, holding them close to my heart, not sure what tomorrow might bring. While transnational caregiving is hard during normal times, as many of us know, it gained a totally new dimension when India declared a sudden lockdown on March 25, 2020, and everything came to a standstill in this complex country without any preparation. This meant all the support services—physical therapy, massage, health monitoring services—as well as the daily visits my mother had received from relatives and friends, were abruptly halted. This generated significant and unprecedented disruptions in everyday life activities, habits, and certainties for my mother and everyone in India. The housing colony where she lives became a fortress, with strict monitoring of essential



Figure 2. Roses and dianthus at the entrance of our apartment in Kolkata, India. Photo by Manashi Ray.

service providers to the residents. My mother's life became confined to her bed and bedroom, with access to a spacious balcony to watch the world pass by, a world which too had gone eerily silent. But nature took no heed of this lockdown imposed on humans and decided to display her beauty with added vigor in gorgeous, vibrant colors. The magnificent jacaranda tree close to my mother's balcony bloomed with lovely purple-blue flowers in summer and autumn against the azure blue skies, and Ma ("mother" in Bangla) reported watching many more *shalik* (sparrow), parrots, and pigeons fly past or visit her verandah in search of food. Even the crows got bolder and swooped closer to her, and they even entered her bedroom on occasion.

This brief essay is a personal narrative of my visit to Kolkata from mid-November 2020 to February 2021. I recount the personal lives of folks unfolding within our home in response to the macro environment of the pandemic in the period before the ferocious second tidal wave of coronavirus hit India, and New Delhi in particular, on April 18, 2021 when the world witnessed breathless Indians dying, unable to find a hospital bed or oxygen. Although the adverse turn of events left me and my family disoriented about our present and the future, overwhelmed and scared, the unusual circumstances also provided opportunities to find new sense and meaning in constructing personal experiences, some of which I share here.

After negotiating with the administration at my university, I obtained special permission to leave for India at the start of Thanksgiving break and to return in mid-February 2021. I recall vividly my joy the day the courteous customer service representative confirmed the purchase of Emirates air tickets for the flight that was going to take me home. After seven or eight months working in isolation within the confines of my apartment and office, overseas travel seemed like a fleeting glimpse of normalcy. I longed to put myself out there, to see what was happening in the world. What's more, winter is the best time in Kolkata, and the 2020-21 winter was even lovelier because of the sudden improvement in the air quality there.

The Emirates flight was unlike any I had taken in my life. All together we might have been five or six passengers in business class on this long journey of 27 hours, with a seven-hour stopover in Dubai. To qualify for this travel from one “hotspot” country to another, leaping across three time zones, it was mandatory to have two negative COVID-19 PCR tests within a 96-hour window of travel time. The preflight preparation was onerous: purchasing the right kind of facemask, plastic glasses, or face shields, bottles of hand sanitizer and wipes, clothing that covered up. In my lifetime, both Delta and Emirates planes have never seemed so squeaky clean, and to my surprise on the Emirates flight I heard the flight crew announce to the passengers when the aircraft was last cleaned and the details of how the aircraft had been sanitized according to safety rules for our safe travel, which I thought was super nice. The airline's preparedness, thought, and care was evident every step of the way, from flight attendants coming only once or twice to deliver our prepackaged meals in plastic covers, blocking middle seats and placing plexiglass where necessary, to spotless cleanliness in the bathrooms with the freshest smelling lavender foaming soap and continuous fresh airflow within the cabin. Truly, it was comforting to be part of this collective informed safety culture practiced by all—the flight crew, guests, baggage handlers, cleaning crew, TSA personnel, etc.—and to know that everyone was helping to keep everyone else safe on this long international flight.

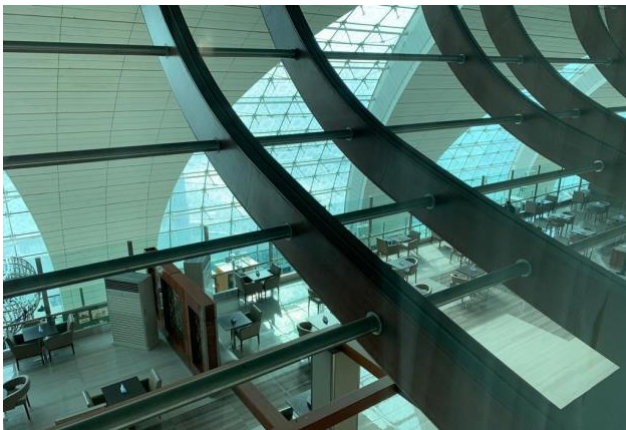


Figure 3. An empty Terminal 3 in Dubai International Airport, November 2020. Photo by Manashi Ray.

But nothing had prepared me for the emptiness and silence of Terminal 3 in Dubai International Airport, the world's busiest airport in terms of international passenger traffic. I love this airport at many levels and pass through it twice a year. The first sight that hit me on reaching Terminal 3 in November 2020 was the few and far between passengers walking through gleaming glass and steel structures shaped like airplane wings, which cover an area of 18,440,000 sq feet of space. Except for a few, the 180 check-in desks were abandoned, and the famous duty-free shops of Le Clos, Gucci, Salvatore Ferragamo,

and Chanel and the counters which sold everything from perfume, wine and spirits, women's accessories, gold jewelry, dates, luggage, and books to chocolate and electronics were empty. The heaven for shoppers worldwide had disappeared into a black hole for the unknown future. With pain and grief, I tried to fathom the loss of business, here where shopping used to be a serious activity for travelers who connected to 260 destinations in the East and West. I recall longing for the electrifying vibrancy and hub of humanity in this place where I have had incredible conversations with fellow travelers, from countries I had known little about, and so many have left lasting impressions and warmed my heart. This time I met no one transiting through Dubai.

On reaching home, I quarantined for 14 days in my bedroom. On those bright winter mornings, sunbeams shone through the mammoth windows into my room and onto my bed, waking me up to a gorgeous, cheerful sight—without any disturbances from honking vehicles—and a hot cup of elaich chai (cardamom tea) and nankhatai (Indian shortbread biscuits) from the local bakery. Drinking chai is an integral part of my family's daily ritual, and I could whiff the smell of its warm, spicy aroma even before the tray was placed at my bedroom door. Later, I would share this morning indulgence with *Ma* on her verandah before taking on the day. I took to writing a journal during my confinement, reading peacefully, making edits to forthcoming publications, conversing endlessly with cousins, aunts, uncles, and friends and watching the gardener prepare the balcony garden for winter flowers with extra TLC. As ironic and brutal as it might sound, I was having a splendid pandemic. In Kolkata, unlike in the US, I started to perceive confinement as a rare privilege for personal reflection, meditation, and spending many happy hours with *Ma*—playing board games in the evenings, reading together her favorite authors and poets, listening to music, watching T20 series of cricket matches and online performances, and having lengthy, meaningful conversations with her because we had no visitors during my twelve-week stay.

Among all the changes in India during the pandemic, the transition to using contactless digital payments for purchases and services small and big has been notable and dramatic in the day-to-day functioning of our household. I am led to believe the transition is widespread across India. So, the fear of coronavirus infection finally accomplished what India's shock demonetization of 2016 failed to do. The fear of touching "hard cash"—often mistakenly perceived as the ultimate carrier of the virus—and concerns over hygiene and social distancing were palpable among all our service providers, from the maids to the gardener, the groceries, vegetable, meat, and milk vendors, the driver, the cleaner, the delivery people from Amazon or Zamato or Swiggy (Indian food delivery companies), to the doctor, home banking personnel, and others. Whatever happened to Indians' traditional attachment to hard currency? The most popular forms of digital payment were Paytm and Google Pay for anyone with Android phones, tablets, or watches. I was both pleasantly surprised and amazed observing the ease with which such transactions were performed by folks who were unlettered or who might not have completed school. The virus has definitely quickened the pace of digital adoption in India. For me as a sociologist, this surely was an indicator of the democratization of power in which the small grocer or general store owner, or any type of service provider, got a tiny economic boost. The empowerment from cashless payments was heartening.

It has made everyone rethink, regardless of their social and economic location, how they will shop and pay in the future.

In this brief reprieve, I was able to see the clear blue skies striated with the green flash of flying parrots and hear sounds I had long forgotten, like the chirping of crickets at night and the low, sweet coo of the solitary spotted dove (*ghoo ghoo pakhi*) on the window balcony. But this came with the sad realization of our incorrigible tendency to overconsume and become insensitive to the fine balances that exist in nature. Our world and my home in Kolkata became quieter, cleaner, and slower in the winter of 2020-21, when the winter flowers—petunias, roses, dianthus, chrysanthemum, pansies, marigold, and sunflower—bloomed in our balcony gardens and



Figure 4. Marigold and chrysanthemum at our apartment in Kolkata, India. Photo by Manashi Ray

window boxes in abundant sunshine with far lower CO² concentrates amid the absence of dense winter fog. There was no one, including stray passersby or a delivery person—a ubiquitous feature of the housing colony now—who did not stop to marvel and destress at this delightful living, growing space. I believe for these few months nature triumphed, reminding me what life could be like if we lived differently. In closing, while acknowledging that coronavirus affects everyone, but not equally, and that widespread vaccination will take years or decades, I firmly believe this “pause,” with all its inconveniences, is an opportunity to reimagine and question our ways of living and working, our consumption behavior and our leisure time, and our personal relationships and structured cooperation. It definitely reminded us, in the Dalai Lama’s words, “how interdependent we are: what happens to one person can soon affect many others,” even on the far side of our planet.

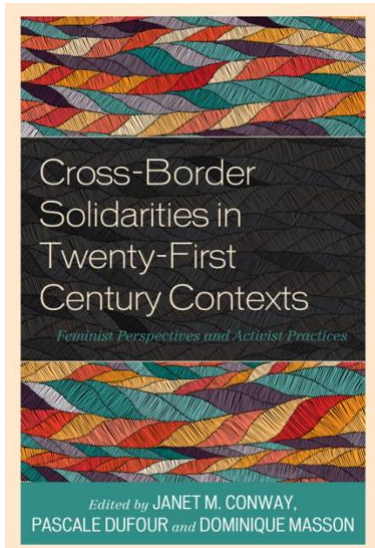
MEMBER NEWS

Celebrations:

Manashi Ray was promoted to the rank of Full Professor at the Department of Psychology and Sociology in West Virginia State University . Congratulations to Dr. Ray!!

Books:

Cross-Border Solidarities in 21st Century Contexts: Feminist Perspectives and Activist Practices. Edited by Janet M. Conway, Dominique Masson and Pascale Dufour, Eds. Rowman & Littlefield, 2021.



Calls for transnational solidarity remain central to social movement struggles the world over. This international collection addresses questions of organizing across political borders and spatialized and racialized differences in the 21st century, in the wake of globalization. Through a series of grounded studies, the collection examines solidarity as a variable, contradictory and contingent practice riven with power relations that is inevitably problematic even as it remains essential. Theoretically, the book problematizes the Euro-modern genealogy of solidarity and inquires into the contributions and limitations of transnational feminism as an approach to study and advance cross-border activist praxis in a variety of contexts. The book offers conceptual tools for the study of solidarity such as transnationalization and translation, as well as key distinctions among counter-hegemonic, intersectional and pluriversal modalities of solidarity apparent on the global left today.

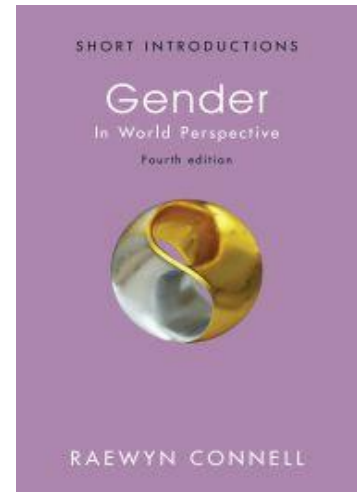


Figure 5. Janet M. Conway

Gender In World Perspective, 4th Edition. By, Raewyn Connell

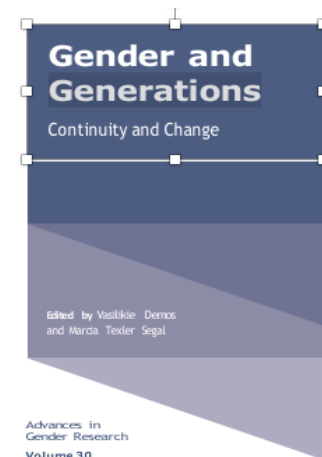
How can we understand gender in the contemporary world? What psychological differences now exist between women and men? How are masculinities and femininities made? And how is gender entwined in global politics and debates over trans issues? Raewyn Connell – one of the world's leading scholars in the field – answers these questions and more. Her book provides a sophisticated yet accessible introduction to modern gender studies, covering empirical research from all parts of the world, in addition to theory and politics. As well as introducing the field, *Gender* provides a powerful contemporary framework for gender analysis with a strong and distinctive global awareness. Highlighting the multidimensional character of gender relations, Connell shows how to link personal life with large-scale organizational structures, and how gender politics changes its form in changing situations. The fourth edition of this influential book brings the statistical picture of gender inequalities up to date, and offers new close-focus case studies of gender research. Like previous editions, it examines gender politics and global power relations, but with added discussion around contemporary issues of intersectionality, populism, gender-based violence, trans struggles and environmental change. It also speaks at the intimate level, about embodied gender and personal relationships. *Gender* moves from personal experience to global problems, offering a unique perspective on gender issues today. See link below,

<https://politybooks.com/bookdetail/?isbn=9781509538997>



GENDER AND GENERATIONS: Continuity and Change Edited by Vasilikie Demos and Marcia Texler Segal.UK: Emerald, 2021

Bringing together theoretical and empirical work on gender and generation, authors consider how generations are measured and demonstrate how they intersect with class, immigration status, sexualities, and race/ethnicity. They identify areas of intergenerational conflict such as ageism and how ageism affects the retirement of women and men differently; consider the intersectional quality of care-giving; and demonstrate generational differences in gender attitudes. While the United States is the primary focus, also examined is intergenerational mobility aspirations among Eastern Indian women. The history of the West is examined by “thinking with” the gendered and generational term “patriarchy,” and noting the absence until recently of a sociology of childhood. Authors examine data from the 20th and early 21st centuries and provide an understanding of dramatic gender-related changes that occurred, for example, in attitudes and in the employment of women outside the home. Focusing on the increased fertility occurring between 1946 and 1964, authors identify the effect baby boomers have had on society and consider their approach to retirement. Attention is paid to overall declining



fertility and aging of populations. Developed as contributors and editors experienced the Covid-19 pandemic, its impact on generations and what research it will generate are considered.

Edited Journal Issue

Janet M. Conway and Nathalie Lebon, Eds. *Popular feminism(s): pasts, presents and futures. Latin American Perspectives*, Volume 48, Issues 4 and 5, July and September 2021.

This thematic double issue focuses on popular feminisms, that is, the diverse forms of gendered agency appearing among Latin America's poor, working-class and racialized communities, and their relation to the politics of feminism and to the broader left in the region. The collection addresses the question of subaltern subjectivities and the building of collective agency in relation to the broader politics of social transformation. It also examines popular feminism as concept with a particular genealogy in relation to histories of the left and to socialist feminism, and inquires into its contemporary relevance, as well as its persistent elision of race and coloniality. The twelve contributions include contextualized studies of grassroots feminist praxis drawn from Brazil, Columbia, Chile, Mexico, Venezuela, and Peru, as well as of national and transnational-scale organizing, and address gendered agency in relation to issues ranging from access to water, opposition to extractivism, the politicization of care work, survival in the face of systemic violence, and Indigenous autonomy. The collection includes a substantive theoretical introduction to popular, racialized and decolonial subjectivities in contention in consideration of contemporary popular feminisms.

Articles/Book Chapters

Ben Dori, S., & Kemp, A. (2020). Undoing age, redefining gender, and negotiating time: Embodied experiences of midlife women in endurance sports. *Time & Society*, 29(4), 1104-1127. <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/0961463X20948987>

Braack, M. K., & Milewski, N. (2020). An explorative approach to the cross-section of international migration and sexual preference: Same-sex couples in Germany. *Genus*, 76(33). <https://doi.org/10.1186/s41118-020-00102-6>

Đurić Kuzmanović T, Pajvančić-Cizelj A. (2020) Economic violence against women: Testimonies from the Women's Court in Sarajevo. *European Journal of Women's Studies*. 2020;27(1):25-40. doi:[10.1177/1350506818802425](https://doi.org/10.1177/1350506818802425)

Gu, Chien-Juh. 2021. "Displaced Social Suffering: Burmese Christian Refugees in a US Midwestern City." *Journal of Refugee Studies* <https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/feaa108>.

Keysan, A. O., & Şentürk, B. (2020). Philanthropists, Professionals and Feminists: Refugee NGOs and the Empowerment of Syrian Women in Gaziantep, Turkey. *International Migration*, 59(1), 143-164 <https://doi.org/10.1111/imig.12728>

Özgür Keysan, A., & Şentürk, B. (2021). Empowerment Perspectives and Practices of Refugee-Related NGOs in Turkey: Family, Protection, or Solidarity?. Journal of Refugee Studies. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/feaa120>

Pajvančić-Cizelj, Ana.(2020) Spatialities of feminist urban politics: networking for 'fair shared cities' in Central and Eastern Europe, Territory, Politics, Governance.

DOI: [10.1080/21622671.2020.1799849](https://doi.org/10.1080/21622671.2020.1799849)

Here is a link with a few remaining free e-copies that I am also happy to share.

<https://www.tandfonline.com/eprint/SXHTMDYDU287YZHGSSCW/full?target=10.1080/21622671.2020.1799849>

Şentürk, B., Kaymaz, Y., & Karadeniz, S. (2021). A Woman's Voice on the Phone Matters: Emotional Labour and Gender in Logistics. In A. J. Griffen (Ed.), Challenges to Integrating Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Programs in Organizations (pp. 111-127). IGI Global.

Şentürk, B., (2020). Precarity, Gender and Migration: The Case of the Professional Syrian Male Migrants in Turkey. In S.Kolukıřık&E.Gün (Eds.), River Flowing North Migration Generating Geographies and International Irregular Migrations (pp.21-34), Peter Lang.

Sen, R., & Gran, B. (2020). Pandemic Perils of Migrant Workers: Inequalities Intensified. In G. Muschert, K. Budd, D. Lane, & J. Smith (Eds.), Social Problems in the Age of COVID-19 Vol 2: Volume 2: Global Perspectives (pp. 73-86). Bristol University Press.
doi:10.46692/9781447360629.009

Announcements:

Starting mid-October, ISA/RC 32 will be hosting a **monthly (or bi-monthly) one-hour Zoom meeting for RC32 members** to facilitate feminist networks and offer encouragement during these difficult times. The President, Melanie Heath, will be hosting these meetings on thematic issues of interest and concern to the membership. Please email our secretary, Alicia Palermo, (aliciaipalermo@gmail.com) with suggestions for topics. Also stay tuned for an email with more information.

Dear RC32 Members and readers of this newsletter,

I hope that this newsletter finds you well!!

If I haven't already done so in personal emails to you, I thank each and every one of you for your contributions and for making this newsletter possible year after year. Please also stay tuned for the call for our winter newsletter for 2021. In the meantime, please take care, stay well and stay safe!

From your newsletter editor – Shweta Majumdar Adur,
Associate Professor, Department of Sociology,
California State University, Los Angeles.